

Should the number of outcomes for an agency, provider, policy, organization or initiative be limited?

Sometimes control agencies, purchasers, funders, or planners insist that agencies, providers, policies, organizations or initiatives restrict themselves to a limited number of outcomes (e.g. 1 or 3 or 5, etc.). This can cause problems because the number of outcomes should reflect the outside world an initiative is attempting to influence and not be constrained by arbitrary limits. Allowing an initiative to have as many outcomes as required is one of the DoView Drawing Rules (B7).

It's a mistake to limit the number of outcomes for an agency or initiative without without considering the number of issues in the outside world the agency is trying to change. For instance, some agencies (e.g. those dealing with internal affairs within a country) are responsible for a wide range of issues. Meanwhile, other agencies are tightly focused on a single topic (e.g. a government law drafting office). If an agency's outcomes are to reflect the outside world, it's fine for a multiple-issue agency to have more outcomes than a single-issue one.

Sometimes it's suggested that this issue can be dealt with by aggregating an initiative or organization's multiple outcomes into just one, or a few, 'overall' summary outcomes. This can be done when used as a PR exercise to make staff feel that they have a common mission. However, from a technical point of view, this approach can unintentionally drive the outcomes for a multi-issue organization to be more generic and less specific. Then, when comparing such an organization's 'outcomes' with those of a single-issue organization, the two different top-level outcomes will seem to be struck at different conceptual levels. In DoView Planning, this is dealt with by always thinking of outcomes, however represented, as being ultimately driven by the outside world, not the organization's internal world; and, second by always visualizing outcomes within a DoView strategy diagram.

Within such a DoView diagram there is room to articulate the lower-level detail of an organization's outcomes structure. When looking at the high-level boxes on the right of the diagram (the 'outcomes'), you can immediately see the boxes just to the left of them, describing all of the areas that the organization has responsibility for. This means that even if there is just one, or only a few high-level outcomes, you can still get to see all of the organization's outcome areas.